



BEFORE

While the armies of Grant and Lee lurched from the ferocious Battle of the Wilderness to the grim struggle at Spotsylvania, concurrent offensives started elsewhere.

SHERIDAN'S PLANS

On **April 5**, General **Philip Sheridan**, one of Grant's protégés from the Western Theater, arrived in Virginia to take command of the **Army of the Potomac's** newly established cavalry corps, whereupon he devised a plan to **defeat Confederate cavalry chief Jeb Stuart**.

SHERMAN MOVES OUT

On **May 7**, General **William T. Sherman**, leading the **Union's second major strategic offensive**, commenced operations against General Joseph E. Johnston in northwestern Georgia. Within a week, Sherman's forces would **outmaneuver Johnston's army** at Rocky Face Ridge and force a retreat to Resaca.

On May 8, 1864, as the opening battles at Spotsylvania were beginning, the 10,000 troopers of General Philip Sheridan's cavalry corps swung into their saddles and set off on a massive raid on Richmond, 50 miles (80km) to the south. Three days later they were nearly at the city's outer defenses when they learned that Confederate cavalry blocked their way.

General Jeb Stuart, with a third of Sheridan's numbers, had hastily deployed across a ridge just north of a tumbledown inn called Yellow Tavern. Stuart's men and mounts were exhausted, but they put up a spirited resistance for three hours. Then, just as a late afternoon thunderstorm broke, Sheridan's troopers charged up the ridge. Galloping along his lines, Stuart shouted encouragement. He had just reached the First Virginia Cavalry, when he was shot and seriously wounded. "Go back! Go back!" he yelled to his men, who were about to break under the force of the assault, "I had rather die than be whipped!" Still they could not hold their line, and were driven off the ridge a few minutes later.

The road to Richmond was open, but Sheridan shied away from the city's defenses and headed east. Rebel cavalry harried his flanks and rear, but eventually he made his way to the Army of the James at Bermuda Hundred. He had fulfilled his vow to "whip Jeb Stuart out of his boots." The seriously wounded Stuart was taken to Richmond, where he died of his wound on the evening of May 12, as fighting raged at Spotsylvania's "Bloody Angle."